

Andrea Ciccaraone

Columbia Business School, Columbia University
665 W 130th St, New York, NY 10027
ac4790@columbia.edu (646) 525-0556
andreaciccaraone.github.io

Placement Chairs:

Mark Dean (mark.dean@columbia.edu)
Martin Uribe (mu2166@columbia.edu)

Placement Administrators:

Jonathan Mendoza (jam2546@columbia.edu)
Amy Devine-Keum (aed2152@columbia.edu)

Education

Columbia University Ph.D. Candidate in Economics (BusEc track)	2020 - 2026
Bocconi University M.S. in Economics and Social Sciences, <i>110/110 Cum Laude</i>	2020
Bocconi University B.S. in International Economics and Finance, <i>110/110 Cum Laude</i>	2017

Research Interests

Political Economy, Media Economics, Organizational Economics

Job Market Paper

An Image is Worth 1000 Words? Partisanship and Attention in Videos

Abstract: Political news today is increasingly consumed in attention-scarce, video-based environments. Yet existing research on media partisanship remains text-centric and implicitly assumes long-form, attentive processing. This paper studies how partisanship operates in video news through the transmission of multi-modal signals: images and text. I develop a multimodal measure of video partisanship to quantify partisan content in video news and decompose the contribution of each modality. I show that the informational strength of each modality depends on attention: images convey partisanship rapidly through affective cues, while text operates through substantive information that requires sustained exposure to accumulate. A survey experiment using real news footage shows how these properties shape viewers' responses to political videos. Partisan images elicit immediate emotional responses even under brief exposure, whereas partisan text shifts policy attitudes only with sustained exposure. Overall, the results show how low-attention video environments reshape persuasion, by filtering out substantive textual information, and relying mostly on the emotional effect of visual signals. Efforts to improve media quality must account for the asymmetric roles of visual and textual content.

Working Papers

The Mechanistic Fixed-Effects Topic Model: Recovering Corporate Culture from Employee Reviews

with [Dan Biderman](#), [David Blei](#), [Wei Cai](#), [Amir Feder](#) and [Andrea Prat](#)

Abstract: Social scientists often use topic models to study documents produced by different authors in different contexts, even though the same broad topic may be expressed differently across environments. Existing methods typically control for this variation ex post and cannot separate global themes from environment-specific language. Their reliance on word counts creates a second problem, as concepts expressed through context, phrases, and tone may never emerge as coherent topics. We introduce the mechanistic Fixed Effects

Topic Model (mFETM), which incorporates fixed effects directly into the generative process and represents documents as interpretable concepts extracted from a large language model with sparse autoencoders (SAEs). Applied to a large corpus of Glassdoor reviews, mFETM recovers topics that are more stable across observed environments without sacrificing fit. At the firm level, mFETM recovers a broader, more interpretable range of general workplace dimensions associated with top employers. A conventional model confounds these with environment-specific topics, such as technology strategy, yielding a narrower and less complete account and losing substantially more fit when environment-associated topics are removed. Finally, the SAE representation allows us to generate counterfactual reviews by steering along the estimated fixed-effect directions, holding a theme fixed while its environment changes.

With or Without Conditions? Equity-Efficiency Tradeoffs in Municipal Transfers in Brazil

with *Luigi Caloi*

Abstract: To improve service delivery, central governments can tie intergovernmental transfers to local policy performance. While performance-based transfers incentivize local governments and generate efficiency gains, they also shift transfers from low- to high-capacity governments, creating welfare-reducing inequities. We study this equity-efficiency trade-off using a bundle of transfer reforms to Brazilian municipalities. When two states tied transfers to relative educational performance, student test scores rose substantially: moving from the 25th to the 75th percentile of per capita conditional transfers increased scores by 0.16 standard deviations. However, the reform also widened funding disparities across municipalities, which translated into disparities in municipal expenditures in multiple sectors. In contrast, contemporaneous reforms to unconditional transfers had negligible effects on student outcomes. We use a simple model of optimal transfers to interpret these findings. Our results suggest that the introduction of performance based transfers delivered large efficiency gains, limited welfare losses from inequities, and was welfare-enhancing. We find minimal evidence of multitasking distortions or score manipulation. Instead, we document improvements in the quality of education inputs and find suggestive evidence of reduced corruption.

Awards, Fellowships, and Grants

CPE Graduate Student Grant Opportunity, <i>Columbia Center for Political Economy</i>	2024
CELSS Seed Grant, <i>Columbia Experimental Laboratory in the Social Sciences</i>	2024
J-PAL's Jobs and Opportunity Initiative Brazil (with Luigi Caloi), <i>J-PAL</i>	2023
Wueller Fellowship for Best Teaching Fellow (Runner-up), <i>Columbia University</i>	2022
Dean's Fellowship, <i>Columbia University</i>	2020 – Present

Seminars & Conferences

IOG-BFI Spring Conference, Economics of Media Bias Workshop,	2026
Bocconi AI and Society Conference, CEPR Media Workshop	
AI+Economics Workshop Zurich	2025

Other Research Experience

Research Assistant to Prof. Andrea Prat and Andrey Simonov, <i>Columbia Business School</i>	2021–2024
Research Assistant to Prof. Cailin Slattey, <i>Columbia Business School</i>	2021–2022
Research Assistant to Prof. Thomas Le Barbanchon, Bocconi University	2019–2020
Research Assistant to Prof. Marco Ottaviani, Bocconi University	2019–2020

Teaching Experience

Main Instructor in Math Camp (Economics MA)	2022 – 2024
Guest Lecturer in Political Economy (PhD), Prof. Andrea Prat	2022 – 2024
TA in Industrial Organization (MA), Prof. Ildikó Magyari	2024

TA in Game Theory and Business (MBA), Prof. Andrea Prat	2022 – 2024
TA in Corporate Finance (UG), Prof. Tri Vi Dang	2023
TA in Math Methods for Economists (MA), Prof. Isaac Bjorke	2022

Academic Service

Referee: *Economica*, *Economic Journal*

Bio

Citizenship: Italian

Gender: Male

References

Andrea Prat

Professor of Economics & Business
Columbia University
andrea.prat@columbia.edu

Suresh Naidu

Professor of Economics &
International and Public Affairs
Columbia University
sn2430@columbia.edu

Mark Dean

Professor of Economics
Columbia University
mark.dean@columbia.edu